

don't care about your background, education, financial prowess, or absolute lack thereof.

You need a financial planner!

There are a number of different credentials, titles, creeds, and pay-scales that flood the financial services industry, and can confuse the heck out of the average bear.

In fact, even the idea of seeing a financial planner may be so daunting (or embarrassing?) that you find ways and excuses to avoid it altogether. Here are a few things to think about in your search, or to compel you to search, depending on your current position.

1. Everybody needs a financial planner

I feel very strongly about this one. I don't care if you have \$70,000 in debts and \$5 to your name (I actually had a client like this once), or the other way around. A financial planner is more than a money manager, and everybody can benefit from their services. And the younger you are when you start to take control of your finances with the help of a planner, the better off you will be in the long run.

2. Call them what you will

I'm calling them financial planners here, but they can be financial

advisors, investment advisors, personal bankers, etc. Technically anybody can hang a shingle out tomorrow calling themselves a financial planner. The trick is . . .

3. What are their credentials?

There are any number of letters and credentials and titles that people can carry. The hallmark for financial planning is the CFP (Certified Financial Planner) designation, which is internationally recognized. The requirements of becoming a CFP entail years of education in addition to extensive work experience.

4. Where do they work?

Check out the company the planner in front of you is representing. Are they a major player in the industry, or a ma-and-pa shop? Some people don't mind ma-and-pa, some do. Are they limited to proprietary investments, or can they recommend what is truly best for you? A large firm generally lends some credibility to the planner, although this isn't a hard-and-fast rule. *Ask your friends and family who they use;* most often referrals work wonderfully.

5. What can I expect?

True financial planning isn't investment management. It isn't banking or